THE LONG WAY ROUND

A short film screenplay

A quiet, observational short film

FADE IN:

EXT. SUBURBAN STREET - LATE AFTERNOON

A quiet street. The sun is low but not setting yet. A sprinkler ticks over a front lawn. Somewhere, a dog barks twice.

JAMIE (17) steps out of his house. Hoodie, old sneakers, phone in hand. He pulls the door shut and stands there for a moment, not quite sure where he's going.

He checks his phone. Nothing important. He locks it and puts it in his pocket.

He starts walking.

EXT. CORNER DAIRY - CONTINUOUS

A delivery van is parked half on the footpath. The dairy owner is dragging a crate of fizzy drinks inside. A little kid on a scooter circles the same patch of pavement, over and over.

Jamie moves around them. The kid's front wheel catches on a crack. He steadies himself, checks if anyone noticed, then carries on.

Jamie almost smiles. Keeps walking.

EXT. RESIDENTIAL STREET - MOMENTS LATER

A breeze moves through a row of trees. One dry leaf skitters along the gutter, gets caught against a storm drain, then breaks free again.

Jamie slows. He watches it travel a few metres before it disappears beneath a parked car.

Across the road, an older woman waters pots on her porch. She turns one towards the light. A radio plays softly through an open window.

Jamie looks up. The clouds are thin and stretched out, lit pale gold at the edges.

He takes his phone out, as if to photograph it. The screen wakes. He looks between the screen and the sky, then puts the phone away.

EXT. SMALL PARK - DUSK

Jamie cuts through a small park. A football rolls across the grass and stops near his shoe.

A BOY (8) runs over, out of breath.

BOY

Sorry.

Jamie nudges the ball back. The boy catches it against his knees and runs off without another word.

At the far end of the park, two teenagers sit on the swings. One is talking with their hands. The other is laughing so hard they have to lean forward.

Jamie watches for a second. Not in a longing way. Just because the sound carries.

He sits on an empty bench. A bird hops along the path, stopping every few steps to inspect something invisible to him.

The park is ordinary. A bin with a loose lid. Mud around the drinking fountain. A faded notice on the fence. The last of the sun catching the tops of the trees.

Jamie sits still. For once, he doesn't reach for his phone.

EXT. BACK STREET - EVENING

He leaves the park and takes a street he doesn't usually use. The houses are close together here. Dinner smells drift from open windows. Cutlery clinks. A television murmurs behind a curtain.

A man struggles to fit a too-large cardboard box into a recycling bin. He gives up, folds one side down and tries again.

Jamie passes a driveway where a small girl is drawing on the concrete with chalk. She has made a lopsided sun, a house, and a person with very long arms.

She steps back to inspect it. Jamie steps around the edge so he doesn't walk over the drawing.

The girl adds a blue line to the sky.

Jamie looks at the drawing for a moment, then carries on.

EXT. HILL AT THE END OF THE BLOCK - SUNSET

The street rises gently. At the top, the houses fall away enough to show a strip of the city in the distance.

Jamie stops by a low fence. The sky has turned orange behind the rooftops. A plane moves slowly across it, almost silent.

He leans against the fence. His shoulders drop. The day hasn't changed. The street hasn't changed. But he is looking at it properly now.

A car passes. Its headlights sweep across the footpath and disappear around the corner.

Jamie breathes in. The air is cool. Somewhere nearby, someone is calling a dog inside.

He stays until the colour drains from the sky.

EXT. JAMIE'S STREET - NIGHT

Jamie walks back along the same street. The sprinkler has stopped. Porch lights are on. A moth circles one of them.

He passes the dairy. The crate is gone. The kid on the scooter is gone too. The street looks almost exactly as it did before.

At his gate, Jamie pauses. He looks back down the road, taking in the parked cars, the dark trees, the lit windows.

He puts his hand on the gate and goes inside.

INT. JAMIE'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

The house is warm. A washing machine turns somewhere out of sight. Jamie leaves his shoes by the door.

His phone buzzes. He checks it. A few messages. Nothing urgent.

He sets it face down on the kitchen counter and opens the back door a little. Night air moves through the room.

He stands there, listening to the ordinary sounds of the house and the street beyond it.

Then he switches off the kitchen light.

FADE OUT.

THE END